

OVERNIGHT EXPLORATION · OCT 2, 2026

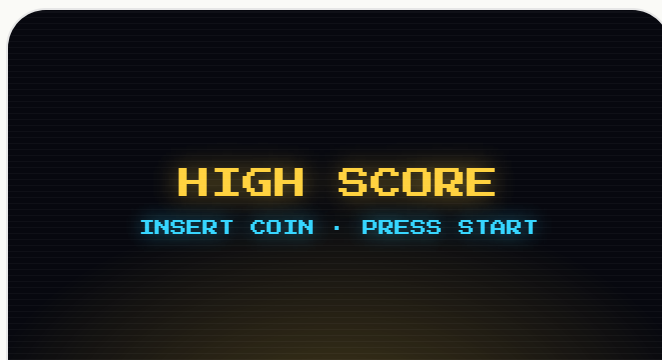
Three ways ToDOMax could look.

You said you weren't sold on the current colors and style. These are three deliberately different directions — each built on the same product (pixel celebrations, packs, collection, streak) but with its own palette, type, tone, and, importantly, its own **shareable artifact**. The research below is why that last part matters more than the colors.

Each guide is a single HTML page: palette with contrast checks, type specimens, every component we have today redrawn, light + dark home screens, the viral artifact, motion notes, do/don'ts, and a mapping table to `lib/theme.ts` so any direction can be adopted without a rewrite.

THE DIRECTIONS

Pick a lane, or a blend.



01

Signal

NYC transit signage meets neo-brutalism. Paper, ink, one yellow. Hard shadows, thick borders, zero fuzz. The most *confident* direction — looks like a tool for adults.

Artifact: the Daily Route card (Wordle-style grid) →

02

Arcade After Dark

Dark-first CRT cabinet. Glowing coin-yellow, laser pink, phosphor green. Leans all the way into the 8-bit identity the celebrations already have. The most *distinctive* direction.

Artifact: weekly High Scores table with initials →

03

Soft Play

Warm pastel pixel. Butter, cocoa, candy accents, chunky rounded buttons with a 3D edge. A pixel block that grows one storey per task. The most *mass-appeal* direction.

Artifact: your block as a weekly postcard →

RESEARCH

Why apps go viral (and what it means for a to-do app).

Short version: nobody shares an app because of its colors. They share an **artifact** the app made about **them**, and they come back because leaving would **lose** something. Style matters because it makes the artifact recognisable at thumbnail size.

1. A native, text-safe artifact

Wordle's grid went viral because it was spoiler-free, instantly recognisable, and pastable into any chat. BeReal's two-camera frame and Duolingo's streak screenshots work the same way: the output *is* the ad.

APPLIED

Each direction ships a share card that contains no task text (privacy), carries the streak, and is unmistakably ToDOMax at 200px wide.

Wordle's "elegant" share grid analysis; Duolingo growth retros

2. Loss aversion beats reward

Mobbin's study of 859 streak implementations: streaks work through fear of losing, not joy of gaining. Duolingo's Streak Freeze lifted retention; friend streaks lifted commitment 22%. Finch shows a repair hammer instead of a zero.

APPLIED

Every direction has a visible streak and a forgiveness mechanic (Snow Day / Continue? / scaffolding) so a miss is a near-loss, not an exit.

mobbin.com streak study; blog.duolingo.com

3. Personality is the moat

Clear (2012) sold 350k copies in a week with no buttons and a heat-map list — people shared videos of a to-do app. Balatro's pixel identity made it recognisable in a sea of card games. Generic doesn't travel.

APPLIED

Each direction has one unmissable signature: Signal's hard shadows, Arcade's glow + scanlines, Soft Play's growing block.

Clear launch coverage; Balatro design write-ups

4. One signal color

Flighty (Apple Design Award) is achromatic with exactly one blue and one yellow. When a product has one color, that color becomes a logo. Our current palette has five competing accents.

APPLIED

Each direction names a single primary action color (Route Yellow / Coin / Coral) and demotes the rest to semantic roles.

Flighty design notes; UXPin 2026 color psychology

5. Fast to first value, tiny commitment

Wordle is one puzzle a day. Duolingo's "Commit to my goal" button copy added 10k daily returns. The ask has to be small and the payoff immediate.

APPLIED

"Add one thing" as the add-bar prompt across all three; the 3-second celebration is already the fastest payoff in the category.

mobbin.com; Duolingo A/B retros

6. Quiet attribution

Loom, Calendly, and Linear grew through the footer of things their users made. Attribution works when it's small and classy, not when it's a watermark.

APPLIED

Share cards carry `todomax.app` in the footer at $\leq 12\text{px}$, never a logo lockup over the content.

PLG case studies (Loom, Calendly, Linear)

COMPARE

Side by side.



01 Signal



02 Arcade After Dark



03 Soft Play

Feels like	A well-made tool. Transit map, Teenage Engineering, Linear with a sense of humour.	A cabinet in a dark bar. Balatro, Celeste, old Nintendo.	A toy you'd keep on a shelf. Finch, Duolingo, Nintendo (modern).
Primary action	Route Yellow #FCCC0A	Coin #FFD23F (glows)	Coral #FF6B57 (3D edge)
Type	Archivo 900 + Inter + Press Start tags	Press Start marquee + Space Grotesk + JetBrains Mono	Nunito 800–900 + Silkscreen tags

Default mode	Light (dark is true black)	Dark (day variant exists)	Light (dark is warm plum)
Viral artifact	Daily Route — Wordle-style 7-square grid, spoiler-free	Weekly High Scores table — initials, rank, cartridges	Postcard — your pixel block skyline for the week
Retention hook	Streak as a route number; "Service change" day skips	"CONTINUE? 9...8..." countdown with Snow Day coin	Scaffolding on missed days; friend streets
Fit with the 8-bit kit	GOOD Kit scenes play in a window with a black border — intentional contrast	PERFECT Kit scenes <i>are</i> the UI language	GOOD Softer backdrop; scenes feel like daydreams
Who it attracts	Design-literate adults, productivity Twitter, people who hate "cute"	Gamers, retro fans, people who screenshot stats	Broadest. Habit-app crowd, families, people who found Signal cold
Biggest risk	Can read as harsh or "designer-y"; yellow on paper fights for attention with 5 line colours	Dark-only alienates daytime/outdoor use; neon can tire; App Store screenshots skew "game"	Most crowded space; one wrong move and it's a Finch clone. Needs the block to be <i>great</i>
Effort to adopt	LOW Token swap + borders/shadows on 4 components	MED Token swap + glow helper + scanline overlay + day variant QA	HIGH Token swap + 3D button + new Block component + postcard renderer
Shareability (gut)	HIGH Grid is proven, text-safe	MED-HI Scores are competitive, less universal	HIGH Skyline is personal, pretty, evolves

RECOMMENDATION

Lead with Arcade After Dark's identity, borrow Signal's discipline.

The 8-bit celebrations are the only thing in this category nobody else has, and Arcade is the only direction where the UI and the celebrations speak the same language — the app would look like its best feature. Signal's rules (one action colour, hard geometry, text-safe share grid) are the ones that keep it from becoming a novelty. Soft Play's **growing block** is the strongest retention idea of the three and is portable: it works as a pixel skyline in Arcade just as well.

Honest counter-case: if the business goal is the broadest possible audience (families, non-gamers), Soft Play is the safer bet and the block/postcard loop is the best growth engine. Arcade is a sharper wedge; Soft Play is a wider net.

1. Read all three in order; note gut reactions before reading the comparison.
2. Decide default mode: dark-first (Arcade) or light-first (Signal / Soft Play). This single choice removes one direction.
3. Pick the artifact you'd personally post. That's the one worth building first; the palette follows it.

Who is the person we picture?

Commuter with a dry sense of humour (Signal), gamer who tracks stats (Arcade), or someone who's tried five habit apps (Soft Play)?

Is dark-first acceptable?

Arcade's day variant works but is clearly the B-side. Most daytime screenshots would be dark.

Social or solo?

High Scores and friend streets both need friends. Daily Route and the postcard work solo. How soon do we want accounts?

How much of the kit is sacred?

Signal and Soft Play recolour nothing in the kit. Arcade would want its cabinet bezel around the scenes.

Name and icon.

None of the three were designed around the current icon. Once a direction is picked, the icon should be re-cut in it.

Blend?

A fourth option is Signal's layout + Arcade's palette in dark, Soft Play's block as the hero. Say the word and I'll draft it.

SOURCES CONSULTED

- Mobbin — "What 859 streak designs taught us" (loss aversion, friend streaks +22%, Streak Freeze, Finch repair hammer)
- Duolingo engineering/product blog — "Commit to my goal" copy test, streak retention
- Wordle share-grid analyses (spoiler-free, text-based, recognisable)
- Clear (Realmac, 2012) launch coverage — gesture-only to-do, heat-map list, 350k first-week sales
- Flighty design notes — achromatic UI with one blue and one yellow; Apple Design Award
- UXPin — "App color psychology 2026" (Headspace calm palette; dark-first needs desaturated accents)
- Neo-brutalism 2026 pattern round-ups (2–4px borders, hard offset shadows, 3–5 colours, industrial yellows)
- Balatro design retrospectives — pixel identity as recognisability
- PLG attribution studies — Loom, Calendly, Linear footers
- NYC MTA / Vignelli signage specs — line colours and type conventions used in Signal

Numbers are as reported by those sources; I didn't independently verify them. Treat them as directional.

DIRECTION 01

Signal.

Your to-do list as subway signage. Black ink, white enamel, one yellow route and nine line colors doing all the work. Nothing soft, nothing decorative — every mark means something.



4 stops today · Uptown via Dentist



WHY THIS DIRECTION

Borrow what made the viral ones legible at a glance.

Signal takes the **Errand Run** concept literally — the map, the route, the stops — and renders it in the most legible visual system ever shipped to millions of people a day: transit wayfinding.

Wordle: the result is the ad

Wordle grew on a green/yellow/grey grid that told the whole story without spoiling

Clear: color = priority, no buttons

Clear (2012) sold 350k copies in two weeks on a heat-map list and pure

anything. Signal gives ToDOMax its own grid: the **Daily Route** strip — one square per task, line-colored by outcome. It's screenshot-native and readable in a feed at thumbnail size.

thehardcopy.co · smithsonianmag.com

gestures. Signal keeps our swipe-to-strike and adds **line-color priority**: the top stop is Express blue, the rest are Local. One glance tells you what matters.

techcrunch.com · technologyreview.com

Flighty: one signal color

Flighty's palette is almost achromatic with a single vivid blue for actions and amber for conversion. Signal reserves **Route Yellow** for the one thing you can do next, and **Express Blue** for the one thing you can buy.

refero.design · mobbin.com

Neo-brutalist UI (2–4px black borders, hard offset shadows, industrial yellows/oranges/greens) is the most active indie-app territory of 2026 — but it only works when the palette is tightly constrained to 3–5 colors with a single dominant background. Signal's discipline is: paper, ink, route, plus line colors used strictly as semantics.

COLOR

Paper, ink, route — and the lines.

The three core colors carry 90% of every screen. Line colors are never decorative: each maps to a meaning or a pack.

Core

#F6F3EC

#FFFFFF

#0B0B0C

#FCCC0A

Paper

Screen background.
Warm, not cream.

Enamel

Cards, signs, inputs.

Ink

Text, 2.5px borders, hard
shadows. Dark mode
background.

Route Yellow

The one primary action.
Add button, TODAY tag,
the drawn route.

Lines (semantic)

#EE352E

Stop Red

Strike-out ink. Delete.
Errand Run pack.

#00933C

Go Green

Done, earned, swipe
reveal. Starter pack.

#0039A6

Express Blue

Links, price capsules,
top-priority stop. Game
Day pack.

#FF6319

Transfer Orange

Garage pack.
Carried-over tasks in the
Daily Route.

#B933AD

Local Purple

Checkout pack.

#808183

Shuttle Grey

Disabled, locked,
placeholder.

CONTEXT	LIGHT	DARK	CONTRAST
Body text on background	Ink on Paper	Enamel on #000	19.4 : 1 / 21 : 1
Primary button	Ink on Route Yellow	Ink on Route Yellow (unchanged)	13.8 : 1
Price capsule	Enamel on Express Blue	same	10.6 : 1
Borders / shadows	Ink, 2.5px, offset 3–4px	Enamel, 2.5px, offset 3–4px	—

Dark mode flips the paper/ink pair and keeps every line color exactly as-is — true black (#000) is correct here, not iOS grey. Neo-brutalist dark surfaces read best at full contrast.

TYPOGRAPHY

Helvetica's loud cousin, plus a bitmap whisper.

Archivo Black for headlines and task text — it has the MTA-Helvetica stance without the license. Inter for everything secondary. Press Start 2P only for 6–8px tags, where it reads as a stamp, not a font.

Display
Archivo 900
34–88px · -0.035em

Cross it off.

Task
Archivo 700
16px · -0.01em

Pick up dry cleaning on 7th Ave

Body
Inter 500
14–15px

Every pack adds new ways to cross something off. Tap any celebration to preview it.

Tag
Press Start 2P
6–8px · uppercase

TODAY **EARNED** **NOT YET**

COMPONENTS

Enamel signs with hard shadows.

TASK ROWS — IDLE / SWIPING / STRUCK

1 Call the dentist about
Thursday

✓ 2 Book the room for Friday

3 ~~Water the fig~~

The index bullet is the line marker: Express
Blue on the first stop, Ink on the rest, Go
Green once struck. Strike ink stays Stop
Red in both modes.

BUTTONS

+ Add stop

Preview

\$1.99

Delete

+ Add stop

+ Add stop

✓ New in your Collection
· Beat the Clock

Press = the sign drops onto its shadow
(translate 3px, shadow 0). No opacity fade,
no scale. 80 ms.

ADD BAR

► Add one stop...

+

PACK CARD



Game Day

Every finished task is a touchdown.

Tecmo-style touchdowns, spikes,
interceptions and the halftime band.

► Touchdown

► Spike

► Halftime Band

+3

6 celebrations

\$1.99

COLLECTION TILES — EARNED / PREVIEWED / HIDDEN / LOCKED





Beat the Clock

x3



Route Cleared

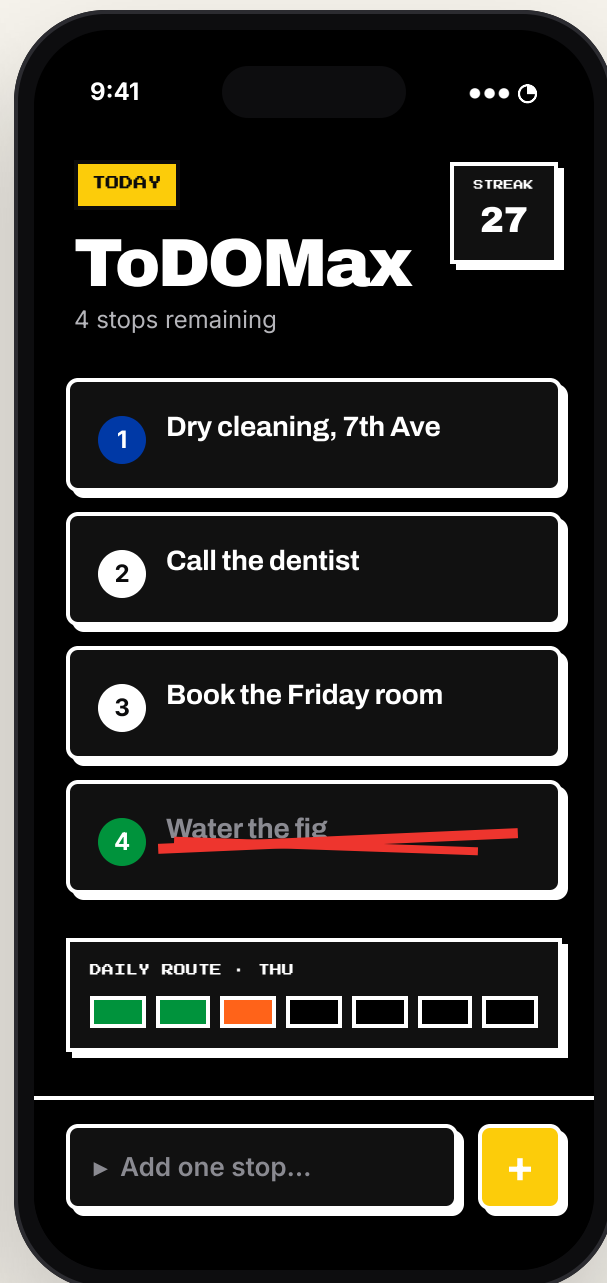
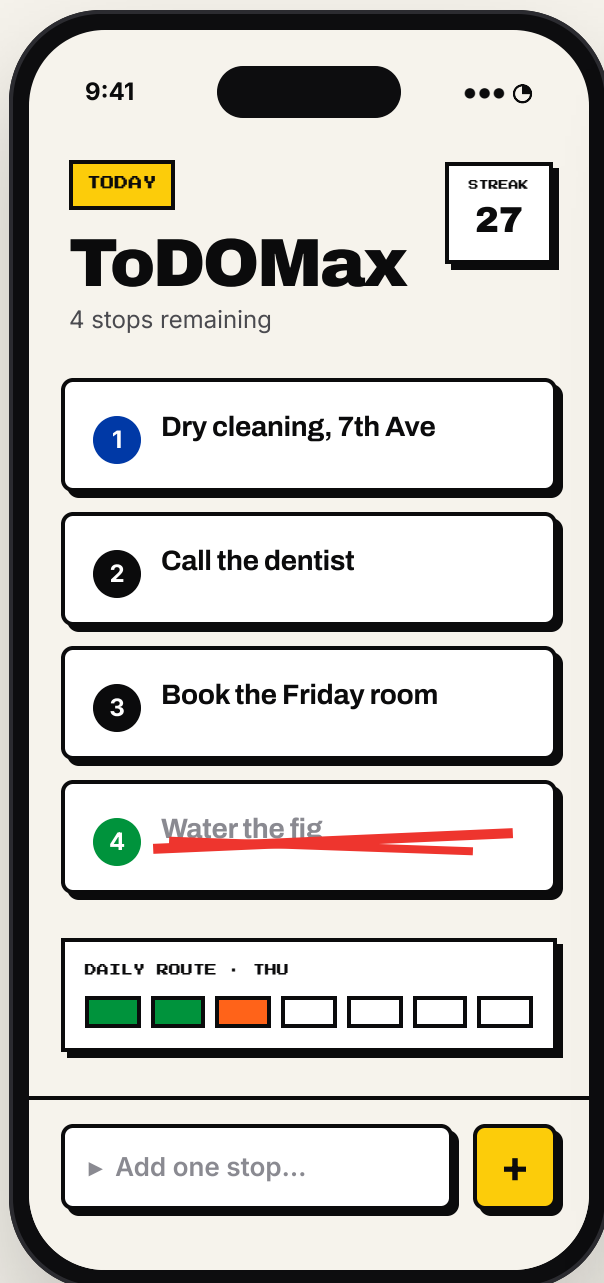
PREVIEWED



NOT YET

SCREENS

Home, both appearances.



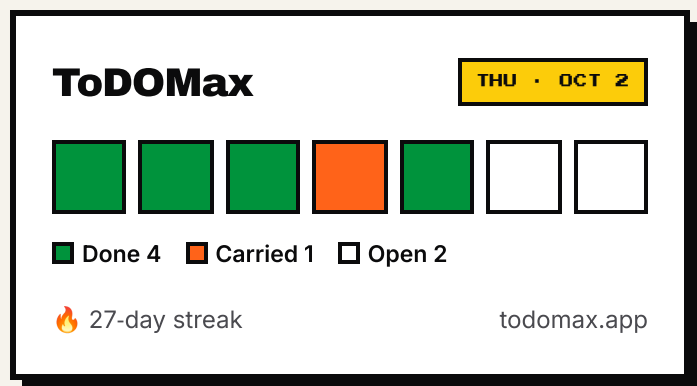
Light. Paper background with no map image — the route lives in the Daily Route strip, not behind the list. Cards are enamel signs; the first stop carries Express Blue.

Dark. True black, white ink, white hard shadows. Every line color is untouched — the point of signage is that it looks the same at night.

VIRAL ARTIFACT

The Daily Route card.

Wordle's lesson: the thing people share should be the *synopsis* of their day, not a screenshot of the app. One square per task, line-colored by outcome, no task text — so it's safe to post and legible at thumbnail size.



How it works

- **Trigger:** after the last task of the day is struck, the celebration ends on the card with a single "Share route" button. Not a popup — it's the end of the movie.
- **Scarcity:** one card per day, generated at the moment you clear the board. Can't be re-rolled.
- **Common knowledge:** only people who use ToDOMax can read the colors. That's the point — it's a signal to the in-group, same as Wordle's grid.
- **Streak is on the card**, because streaks are about not losing (Mobbin's study of 859 streak designs). A 27 next to the

squares is the stake.

- **Attribution:** a quiet URL in the footer. Loom's 3-second outro, Calendly's footer — small, permanent, never a watermark.

MOTION & FEEL

Mechanical, not bouncy.

Press

Sign drops onto its shadow: `translate(3,3)`, shadow → 0. 80 ms, no easing curve to speak of.

Strike

Keep the pen scribble as-is. Stop Red, 5px, zero radius ends — a grease pencil, not a marker.

Collapse

Height collapses with the overdamped spring already shipped; the hard shadow collapses with it.

Celebrations

Kit animations run unchanged. Their banners already use these colors (`bannerRed`, `bannerYellow`). Add a 2px ink border to the banner.

Haptics

Unchanged: light ticks per stroke, Success on land, selection on arm.

Reduce Motion

Hard shadows don't move; only the drop. Already compatible.

RULES

Do / Don't

DO

- Use Route Yellow for exactly one element per screen.
- Give every line color a meaning before it appears.
- Keep borders 2.5px, radius ≤ 6 px, shadows hard and offset.
- Let text do the work — Archivio 900 at 34px+ is the hero image.
- Use Press Start 2P at 6–8px only, uppercase, inside a bordered tag.

DON'T

- No gradients, no blur, no translucency. Signage is opaque.
- No map image behind the list — the route is the strip, not wallpaper.
- No soft shadows or rounded-rect "cards"; a sign is a sign.
- Don't tint the dark mode grey; it's black.
- Never put task text on the share card.

Mapping to `lib/theme.ts`

TOKEN	LIGHT	DARK
<code>bg</code>	<code>#F6F3EC</code>	<code>#000000</code>
<code>surface</code>	<code>#FFFFFF</code>	<code>#111113</code>
<code>text /</code> <code>borderStrong</code>	<code>#0B0B0C</code>	<code>#FFFFFF</code>
<code>accent (strike)</code>	<code>#EE352E</code>	
<code>gold</code> → rename <code>route</code>	<code>#FCCC0A</code>	
<code>green</code>	<code>#00933C</code>	
<code>blue</code>	<code>#0039A6</code>	
<code>buttonFill</code>	<code>#FCCC0A (ink text)</code>	<code>#FCCC0A (ink text)</code>
shadows	Replace blur shadows with <code>shadowOffset {3,3} · radius 0 · opacity 1</code> ; Pack accents become line colors.	

Direction 01 · Signal — ToDOMax design exploration. Companion files: [Overview](#) · [02 Arcade After Dark](#) · [03 Soft Play](#).

DIRECTION 02

ARCADE AFTER DARK

The app most people will open at 11pm, designed for 11pm. A dark cabinet, phosphor text, one coin-yellow button and celebrations that look like they belong on the screen — because this time the whole screen is the arcade.

1UP 00027 HI 00041 CREDITS 19

WHY THIS DIRECTION

**The celebrations are already pixel art.
Stop fighting them.**

Today the kit animations (bannerRed, typeGreen, LCD watch) play on top of a cream paper UI — two visual systems sharing a screen. Arcade makes the UI and the celebrations one world, so a completed task feels like clearing a level, not opening a popup.

Balatro: personality beats polish

A poker roguelike with CRT shader and hand-drawn pixel jokers became 2024–25’s word-of-mouth hit. Not because it was technically impressive — because it

Duolingo: a streak you defend

Mobbin’s study of 859 streak designs: the sting of losing a streak is about *who you are*, not the number. Arcade reframes the streak as a **HI SCORE** you’re defending —

was **unmistakable in a 2-second clip**.
Arcade gives ToDOMax that: nobody else's
to-do list glows.

Balatro visual identity analyses, 2025

the oldest loss-aversion loop in gaming,
and one every player already
understands.

mobbin.com · blog.duolingo.com

Flighty: the control-room drop

Flighty's page goes from white departure
board to a "deep midnight control room
with glowing screens". Its dark mode is
the *premium* mode. Arcade is dark-first for
the same reason; the "day" variant is the
fallback, not the default.

refero.design — Flighty design system

Caution from the research: dark-first UIs need desaturated accents (fully saturated colors
vibrate on dark) and strict contrast checks. Every phosphor color below has been pulled
back from pure neon and tested against the cabinet surfaces.

COLOR

Cabinet, phosphor, one coin.

Surfaces

#07080F

Void

Screen. Not pure black —
leaves room for glow.

#0F1120

Cabinet

Cards, sheets.

#171A2E

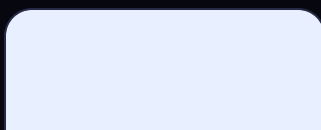
Cabinet 2

Elevated: inputs, chips,
pressed.

#262A45

Bezel

1px borders. Never
thicker.



#9AA3C7

Phosphor

Primary text. Slightly blue-white.

Phosphor 2

Secondary text.

Signals

#FFD23F

Coin

Primary action. The only yellow. Glows 24px @ 35%.

#FF3D7F

Laser

Strike ink, delete. Hot but not neon.

#39FF8A

Power

Done, earned, 1UP, hi-score.

#35D6FF

Plasma

Links, price capsules, priority LED.

#FF8A3D

Ember

Garage pack.

#B07CFF

Violet

Checkout pack.

CONTEXT	PAIR	CONTRAST
Body text	Phosphor on Void	17.9 : 1
Secondary text	Phosphor 2 on Cabinet	7.6 : 1
Primary button	#1A1400 on Coin	13.2 : 1
Price capsule	#04202A on Plasma	11.0 : 1
Day variant	#0F1120 on #EEF1F8 · same signal colors, glows off	16.1 : 1

Glow is a border-radius-aware shadow in the signal color at 30–40% alpha. It appears only on Coin (always), Power (earned/hi-score) and Laser (strike). Nothing else glows, or nothing reads as special.

TYPOGRAPHY

Bitmap for the marquee, grotesk for the game.

Press Start 2P becomes a real headline face here — the app name, HI SCORE, section marquees — but never body copy. Space Grotesk carries tasks and text: it has just enough geometry to sit next to a bitmap without clashing. JetBrains Mono for numbers that count.

Marquee
Press Start 2P
14-28px • line 1.3

LEVEL CLEAR

Task
Space Grotesk 600
16px

Pick up dry cleaning on 7th Ave

Body
Space Grotesk 400/500
14-15px

Every pack adds new ways to cross something off. Tap any celebration to preview it.

Counter
JetBrains Mono 700
tabular

00027

Tag
Press Start 2P
6-7px

INSERT TASK

1UP

LOCKED

COMPONENTS

Glass over a dark cabinet.

TASK ROWS — IDLE / SWIPING / STRUCK

Call the dentist about Thursday



1 Book the room for Friday

Water the fig

A Plasma LED on the left edge marks the top stop. Strike is Laser with glow — the only time pink appears on the home screen.

BUTTONS

+ Insert task

Preview

\$1.99

Delete

+ Insert task

+ Insert task

Restore



New in your Collection
· Beat the Clock

ADD BAR

Insert task...



A blinking block cursor replaces the sparkle pip. It's the most recognisable "type here" in the world.

PACK CARD = CARTRIDGE



Game Day

Every finished task is a touchdown.

Tecmo-style touchdowns, spikes, interceptions and the halftime band.

► Touchdown

► Spike

► Halftime Band

+3

6 celebrations

\$1.99

COLLECTION TILES — EARNED / PREVIEWED / HIDDEN / LOCKED



Beat the Clock

x3



Route Cleared

PREVIEWED



???

NOT YET

SCREENS

Home — night (default) and day.

9:41



PLAYER 1 • THU

HI SCORE

00027

TODOMAX

4 tasks remaining

Dry cleaning, 7th Ave

Call the dentist

Book the Friday room

~~Water the fig~~

Insert task...



9:41



PLAYER 1 • THU

HI SCORE

00027

TODOMAX

4 tasks remaining

Dry cleaning, 7th Ave

Call the dentist

Book the Friday room

~~Water the fig~~

Insert task...



Night. No map wallpaper — a faint plasma glow from the top edge, scanlines at 3.5% and cards lit from above. The streak is a HI SCORE in Power green.

Day. A cool off-white cabinet with the glows switched off; the same signal colors, darkened slightly for contrast (Power → #0FA85A on light).

VIRAL ARTIFACT

The high score table.

Every arcade ends on the same screen, and everyone knows how to read it. A weekly table: your streak and tasks cleared against your friends' initials, plus the cartridges you've earned. BeReal proved social stakes with a tiny mechanic; this is ours.



How it works

- **Initials, not names.** Three letters is the most private leaderboard ever invented — and it's fun to pick them.
- **Streak = score.** It's defended, not accumulated. Losing your place on the table is the loss-aversion loop, with the friend layer Duolingo found lifts daily completion 22%.

- **Cartridge shelf** shows earned celebrations as colored carts — the Collection board, compressed into one line.
- **Weekly reset.** A new table every Monday keeps newcomers in the game (BeReal's daily window, stretched to a week).
- **Solo mode:** with no friends added, the table shows your past four weeks instead — you versus you.

MOTION & FEEL

Snappy, lit, a little electric.

Press

Scale 0.96 + brightness 0.9, spring back.
Coin button's glow tightens on press (24px → 12px).

Strike

Existing scribble, Laser color, with a glow that blooms to 40% on land and settles at 20%.

1UP

Swipe reveal is Power green with glow; the "DONE!" label becomes "1UP". The land haptic stays Success.

Celebrations

Unchanged — but the overlay backdrop is Void at 70% so the kit scenes read as "on the cabinet screen". Banner colors already match.

Cursor

Block cursor blinks at 1.1s (steps 2). Respect Reduce Motion: solid, no blink.

Scanlines

3.5% overlay on screen backgrounds only. Never on text containers. Off under Reduce Transparency.

RULES

Do / Don't

DO

- Glow only Coin, Power and Laser — and only at 20–40% alpha.
- Keep bezels 1px; depth comes from gradient + glow, not borders.
- Use Press Start 2P for marquees ≥ 14 px or tags ≤ 7 px. Nothing in between.
- Tabular, zero-padded numbers everywhere a score appears.
- Ship dark as default; treat day as the accessibility fallback.

DON'T

- No pure black (#000) and no pure neon (#0F0, #F0F). Both read cheap.
- No pixel font in body copy or task text. Ever.
- No more than one glowing element in a card.
- Don't add a CRT curvature or chromatic aberration — scanlines are the limit.
- Don't show friends' real names on the table.

Mapping to `lib/theme.ts`

TOKEN	NIGHT (DEFAULT)	DAY
<code>bg</code>	<code>#07080F</code>	<code>#EEF1F8</code>
<code>surface</code> / <code>inputBg</code>	<code>#0F1120</code> / <code>#171A2E</code>	<code>#FFFFFF</code> / <code>#FFFFFF</code>
<code>text</code> / <code>textSecondary</code>	<code>#E8F0FF</code> / <code>#9AA3C7</code>	<code>#0F1120</code> / <code>#5E6688</code>
<code>border</code>	<code>#262A45</code>	<code>rgba(15,17,32,.1)</code>
<code>accent</code> (strike)	<code>#FF3D7F</code>	<code>#E8306E</code>
<code>gold</code> → <code>coin</code>	<code>#FFD23F</code> (button text <code>#1A1400</code>)	
<code>green</code>	<code>#39FF8A</code>	<code>#0FA85A</code>
<code>blue</code>	<code>#35D6FF</code>	<code>#0A9ECF</code>

new: `glow(color)`

shadowColor = color, radius 12–24, opacity .3–.4 — iOS only; Android elevation 0.

AppBackground

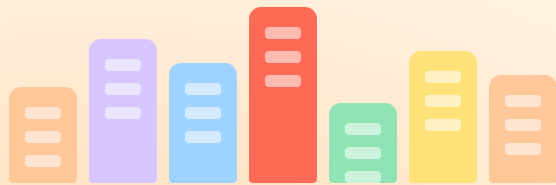
Drop the map JPG; radial plasma gradient + 3.5% scanline tile (tiny PNG, repeat).

Direction 02 · Arcade After Dark — ToDOMax design exploration. Companion files: [Overview](#) · [01 Signal](#) · [03 Soft Play](#)

DIRECTION 03

Soft Play.

Pixel art, but the kind you want to hug. Butter backgrounds, rounded everything, candy accents — and a little pixel block that builds itself up as you finish things. The mass-market direction: friendly enough for your mum, playful enough to screenshot.



WHY THIS DIRECTION

The apps that stuck gave you something to take care of.

Streaks are about not losing. Finch and Duolingo both learned that a number is easy to abandon, but a *thing* you've been raising isn't. Soft Play gives ToDOMax a thing: your block — a row of pixel buildings that grows one storey per task.

Finch: progress you can see grow

Duolingo: "Commit to my goal"

"Instead of tracking your habits, you're raising something." Finch's bird grows when you show up and doesn't when you don't — and a missed day shows a **repair hammer**, not a blank. Soft Play's block does the same: a storey is added per task, and a quiet day shows scaffolding you can still finish.

mobbin.com — 859 streak designs

Changing one button from *Continue* to *Commit to my goal* brought 10,000 more people back daily. Soft Play's copy is first-person and warm: "Add one thing", "Done for today", "Keep my street lit". The product talks like a friend, not a system.

blog.duolingo.com · mobbin.com

Headspace: calm sells

Headspace's muted oranges and soft blues deliberately avoid sharp contrast. Productivity apps skew anxious; the one that *doesn't* is the one people recommend. Soft Play keeps saturation high but tone warm — candy, not neon.

uxpin.com — app color psychology (2026)

Risk to name honestly: this is the most crowded aesthetic (Finch, Habitica, Forest, Streaks). The differentiator has to be the pixel block + the kit's cinematic celebrations — nobody in this space has a 3-second pixel movie when you finish a task.

COLOR

Butter, cocoa, and five candies.

Base

#FFF6E5

Butter

#FFFFFF

Milk

Cards, inputs.

#2B2730

Cocoa

#6E6677

Cocoa 2

Secondary text.

Screen background. Warm, bright.

Text. A warm charcoal — never pure black.

Candies

#FF6B57

Coral

Primary action and strike ink. Deep: #E4523F for the 3D edge.

#8FE3B4

Mint

Done, earned, ground. Deep: #2FA86E.

#9FD3FF

Sky

Links, price (deep #2F8FDB), hero wash.

#FFE27A

Sun

Streak badge, TODAY, Game Day. Deep: #D9A800.

#FFC89B

Peach

Errand Run pack.

#D7C6FF

Lilac

Checkout pack.

CONTEXT	PAIR	CONTRAST
Body text	Cocoa on Butter	13.9 : 1
Primary button	White on Coral	3.3 : 1 — large/bold text only (≥ 15px 800)
Price capsule	White on Sky Deep	4.6 : 1
Mint label	#0F4A2E on Mint	8.9 : 1
Dark mode	#F6F0F7 on #1C1920 · candies unchanged, "deep" edges lightened 10%	15.2 : 1

Every candy has a "deep" partner used as a 4–8px bottom edge on buttons and badges — the chunky, pressable look (Duolingo's buttons work this way). The pastel is the face; the deep is the side.

T Y P O G R A P H Y

Round and heavy, with a pixel wink.

Nunito at 800–900 everywhere. One family keeps it simple and friendly; the weight keeps it from going twee. Silkscreen — a cleaner, rounder bitmap than Press Start — only for 7–9px labels and the pixel block's captions.

Display
Nunito 900
32–72px • -0.03em

Done for today.

Task
Nunito 800
16px

Pick up dry cleaning on 7th Ave

Body
Nunito 600/700
14–15px

Every pack adds new ways to cross something off. Tap any celebration to preview it.

Pixel label
Silkscreen
7–9px

TODAY

EARNED

NOT YET

C O M P O N E N T S

Chunky, rounded, pressable.

TASK ROWS — IDLE / SWIPING / STRUCK



Call the dentist about
Thursday



Book the room for Friday



~~Water the fig~~

A visible checkbox returns — this direction is for people who want the familiar affordance. Swipe still works; the box just fills Mint when the pen lands.

BUTTONS

+ Add one thing

Preview

\$1.99

Done for today

+ Add one thing

+ Add one thing



New in your Collection
• Beat the Clock

Primary buttons have an 8px "deep" edge and press down 6px — the physical, Duolingo-style button. Haptic: selection on press, Success on release.

ADD BAR

✦ Add one thing...



PACK CARD



Game Day

Every finished task is a
touchdown.

Touchdowns, spikes, interceptions and
the halftime band.

► Touchdown

► Spike

► Halftime Band

+3

6 celebrations

\$1.99

COLLECTION TILES — EARNED / PREVIEWED / HIDDEN / LOCKED





Beat the Clock

x3



Route Cleared

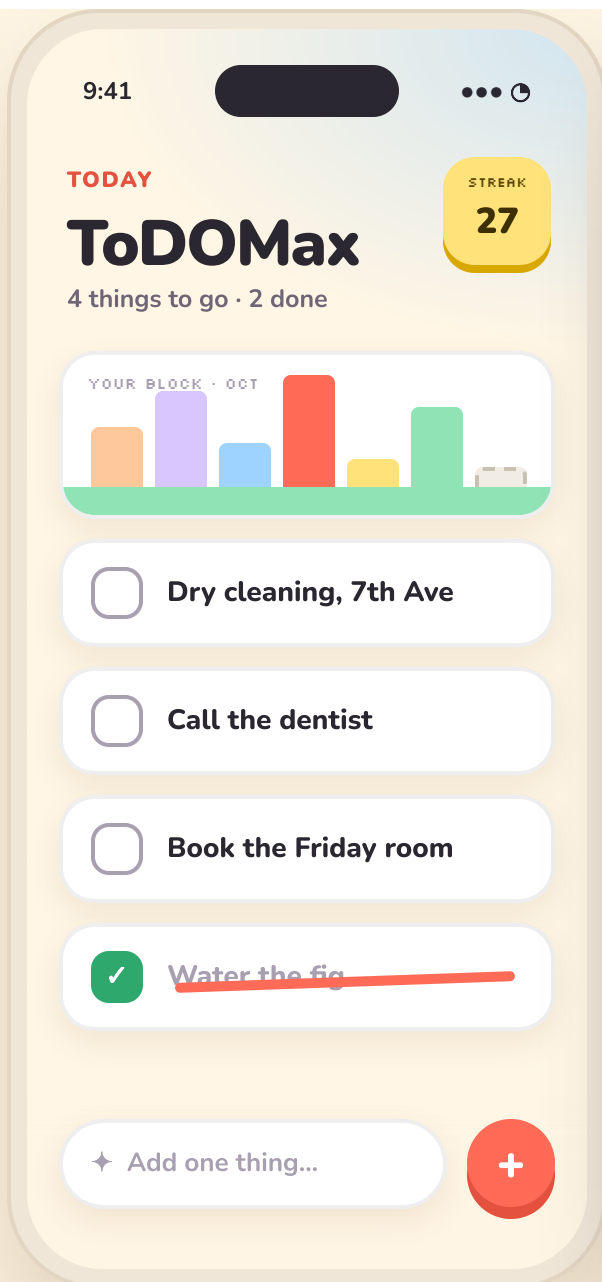
PREVIEWED



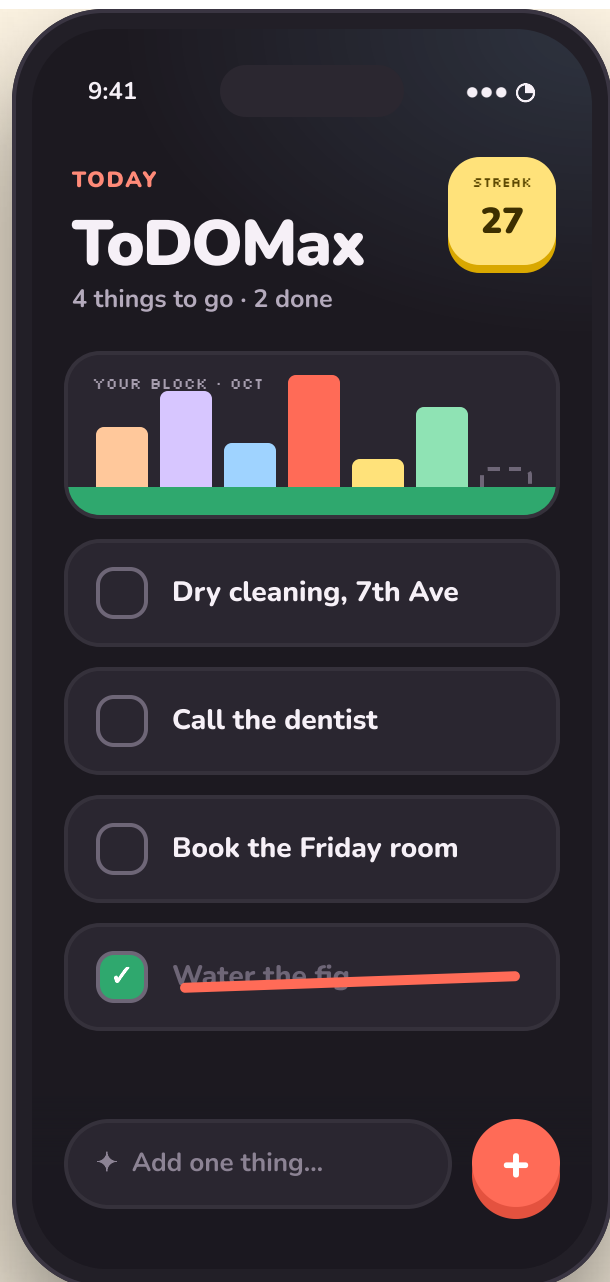
NOT YET

SCREENS

Home, with your block up top.



Light. The pixel map wallpaper is replaced by **your block**: one building per day this month, one storey per task. Today's building is the dashed one — it's scaffolding until you finish something.

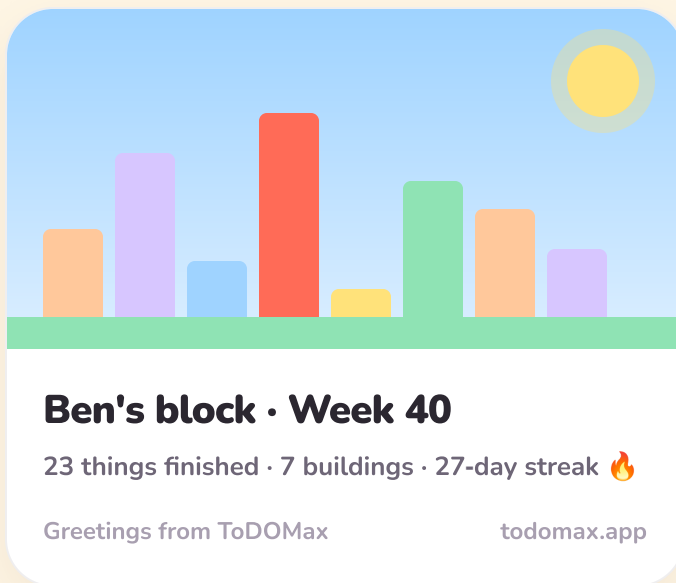


Dark. A warm, plum-tinted charcoal rather than blue-black; candies stay bright because they're the point. Night in the city, lights on.

VIRAL ARTIFACT

The postcard.

At the end of each week (or month) your block becomes a postcard: the skyline you built, the streak, no task text. It's the Finch bird photo, the Duolingo year-in-review, the thing people post because it's *theirs*.



How it works

- **Generated, not screenshotted.** The postcard is rendered from your week's data — tall buildings on big days, scaffolding on quiet ones. Every one is different.
- **Identity:** "Ben's block." The research is blunt — people share things that are about *them*. The skyline is a portrait.
- **Repair, don't punish.** A missed day is a dashed building you can still complete tomorrow (Finch's hammer). The streak never resets to zero mid-week; it pauses.
- **Friend streets:** add a friend and your blocks sit side by side — the 22% friend-streak lift, without a leaderboard.
- **Packs show up on the skyline.** Earn a Game Day celebration and a stadium appears; Garage adds a gas station. The store becomes world-building.

MOTION & FEEL

Squishy, warm, quick.

Press

Buttons depress 6px onto their deep edge and spring back (damping 14, stiffness 320). Scale stays 1.

Strike

Existing scribble in Coral, slightly thicker (5px, round caps). The checkbox fills Mint and pops to 1.15 on land.

Block grows

After the celebration, today's building gains a storey with a 180 ms overshoot spring. This is the second payoff — tiny, every time.

Celebrations

Kit scenes unchanged; overlay backdrop is Butter at 60% instead of ink, so the movie feels like a daydream rather than a cut to black.

Sound

Keep the kit sounds; consider a soft "plink" for the storey landing.

Reduce Motion

Buttons don't depress; the block updates without spring. Already supported by the current hook.

RULES

Do / Don't

DO

- Pair every candy with its deep edge; the pastel alone looks flat.
- Keep radius $\geq 18\text{px}$ on cards, 999 on buttons and inputs.

DON'T

- No gradients on controls — only on the hero wash and postcard sky.
- No pure black, no grey text below 4.5 : 1 for body copy.

- Write copy in first person and present tense — "Add one thing", "Done for today".
- Let the block be the only illustration on the home screen.
- Use Silkscreen for $\leq 9\text{px}$ labels only.

- Don't add a mascot character. The block is the companion; a bird would make it Finch.
- Don't reset the streak to zero mid-week. Pause it.
- No more than two candies per component.

Mapping to `lib/theme.ts`

TOKEN	LIGHT	DARK
<code>bg</code>	<code>#FFF6E5</code>	<code>#1C1920</code>
<code>surface</code>	<code>#FFFFFF</code>	<code>#2A2630</code>
<code>text</code> / <code>textSecondary</code>	<code>#2B2730</code> / <code>#6E6677</code>	<code>#F6F0F7</code> / <code>#B4AABC</code>
<code>accent</code> (strike, primary)	<code>#FF6B57</code> · deep <code>#E4523F</code>	
<code>green</code>	<code>#8FE3B4</code> face · <code>#2FA86E</code> deep/text	
<code>blue</code>	<code>#2F8FDB</code> (capsules) · <code>#9FD3FF</code> (washes)	
<code>gold</code> → <code>sun</code>	<code>#FFE27A</code> · deep <code>#D9A800</code>	
new: <code>deepEdge</code>	Rendered as a sibling View 6–8px tall behind the button; press = <code>translateY(6)</code> .	
<code>AppBackground</code>	Replace the map JPG with a radial Sky wash + the Block component (data-driven from completions).	

Dark